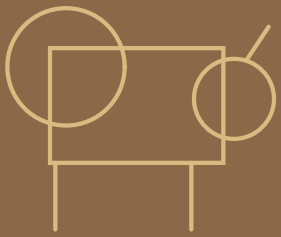
HISTORIES OF OUR WORLD

Bison on the Plains



ANIMALS

The Den Editions

ORIGINAL SAMPLE ESSAY

01 / ANIMALS

More than a herd

For many Indigenous peoples of the Great Plains, bison supplied food and materials and held deep cultural importance. Relationships with the animal differed across communities. Treating those relationships as one identical tradition would flatten a much richer history.

During the nineteenth century, commercial slaughter devastated bison populations. Their destruction also harmed Indigenous livelihoods and independence. The disappearance of herds cannot be understood as an isolated wildlife event; it belongs to the history of settlement, power, and land.

02 / ANIMALS

Keeping a species alive

By the late nineteenth century, bison had been brought close to extinction. Small surviving herds and subsequent protection and breeding efforts helped prevent the species from disappearing. Yellowstone became an important part of that history.

Survival and restoration are different achievements. Keeping animals alive does not automatically restore their former range or their cultural and ecological relationships. The history of bison offers a way to examine both the damage people caused and the long work involved in repairing it.

About this edition

This is a modern original sample essay created for The Den's public demo. It is not a historical original or a transcription of a historical document. The prose and geometric cover artwork were created for this collection.

Sources and further reading
These museum and library pages informed the historical details. Follow the links to explore their fuller accounts and collections.

National Park Service: People and Bison

https://www.nps.gov/subjects/bison/people.htm

National Park Service: History of Bison Management

https://www.nps.gov/yell/learn/historyculture/bison-management.htm

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